I am Philip Brandon Makil, and I am proud to be part of the first batch of the Cooking for Life Program in 2010.

This journey began in 2009. At the time, I was already in my second year taking up a Bachelor of Science in Hotel and Restaurant Management and was supposed to continue my college education. However, due to financial difficulties, my family could no longer support my studies. I had no choice but to stop schooling and find work. I started working at a grocery store for three months, uncertain of what the future would hold.

Then, an opportunity came that would change my life forever — a scholarship under the Cooking for Life Program of CCA Manila. At first, I was not particularly interested in culinary arts. But when we were introduced to inspiring mentors like Chef Marco and Chef Roby Coco, my perspective changed. Their passion and dedication opened my eyes to a new path. The program was truly life-changing. We learned essential skills such as knife techniques, sauce preparation, international cuisines, and most importantly, the right attitude inside the kitchen.

After months of classroom learning, we were required to undergo on-the-job training. I was fortunate to be one of the students who excelled and was eventually absorbed into the kitchen team. I began working at the grill station in Le Monet Baguio, which became the stepping stone to opportunities abroad.

Soon after, I worked as a Sushi Chef in Saudi Arabia for four years. However, like many others, I was affected by the pandemic and had to return to the Philippines. Determined to move forward, I opened a small pizza franchise business while also accepting sushi platter orders on the side. My wife and I found fulfillment in running our small venture, yet deep inside, I still carried a lifelong dream — to work abroad again and experience snow. It may seem like a simple dream to some, but it was something I had held onto since childhood.

In 2023, another door opened when I was given the opportunity to work in Hungary as a Sushi Chef. For the first time, I was able to work in Europe. After a year, new opportunities emerged, and together with a fellow chef, we took a leap of faith and moved to Austria.

Today, I am a Chef de Partie in Gosau, working alongside international chefs in a diverse and dynamic kitchen environment. It is a fulfilling role that constantly challenges and inspires me.

From being a grocery store worker at 20 years old to becoming an international chef 16 years later, my journey has been nothing short of remarkable. I often wonder what my life would have been like had I not been given the chance through this program. I will forever be grateful to CCA Manila and to Eric Singson for creating this life-changing opportunity for the youth of Ilocos Sur.

This program did not just teach me how to cook — it gave me a future.